



CHICAGO 2026

An Afternoon With Art

A family, a birthday, and an unexpected afternoon at the Art Institute of Chicago

BEFORE THE PAINTINGS

The trip came first.

We were in Chicago because my youngest son, **Chidiebere**, was turning twenty-four.

Chi Chi and I had come with our three sons: Obi, Nnamdi, and Chidiebere. It was a chilly, rainy day, the kind that made several hours inside the Art Institute feel like a particularly good idea.

I did not go into the museum intending to write a book. I was a father spending a weekend with his family. That matters, because the family context changed what I saw -especially when I later stood before Abraham and Isaac.

There is something increasingly precious about getting all of us into the same place. The boys are adults now. We were five adults moving through Chicago together, and the museum happened inside that larger event.



PhotoScan by Google Photos

HOW I WANT TO REMEMBER IT

Three things were happening at once.

WHAT THE MUSEUM TOLD ME

Names, dates, materials, artistic movements, histories. I needed that information, but I do not want it to become the voice of this book.

WHAT I ACTUALLY SAW

Faces, surfaces, scale, color, awkward details, things that made me walk closer or step back. Sometimes I noticed something before I knew why it mattered.

WHAT THE WORK CAUSED ME TO THINK ABOUT

Fatherhood. Faith. Medicine. Nigeria. Technology. Labor. Aging. Mortality. Sometimes nothing so grand - only surprise or confusion.

I do not want every work neatly decoded.

Sometimes the most accurate sentence is simply: *I am still not sure what I think about this.*

The photographs matter too. Wherever possible, these are the pictures I actually took in the galleries - including imperfect angles, reflections, frames, and the occasional person entering the edge of the image. They are evidence of an encounter, not reproductions for an art-history textbook.



01

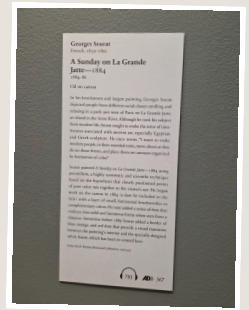
Abraham

Jean II Restout - *The Sacrifice of Abraham*

It was the anguish in Abraham's face that stayed with me. I had read Genesis 22 for decades. That afternoon, with my three adult sons somewhere in the same museum, I stopped seeing Abraham primarily as a patriarch and saw him as a father.

The painting made me remain in the moment Scripture moves through quickly: the son, the father, the knife, and the interruption.

Art made the story human again.



02

From Across the Room

Georges Seurat - *A Sunday on La Grande Jatte*-1884, 1884-86

My strongest impression came from across the room. From a distance there was a world: people, water, umbrellas, a Sunday afternoon. Close up, that world broke into marks of color.

The museum label explained the method: points of pure color were meant to mix in the viewer's eye, while Seurat used a modern Parisian subject to seek something almost timeless.

It made me think about scale in medicine. A measurement can be true. A diagnosis can be true. A data point can be true. But so is the human being that appears only when I step back far enough.



03

A Face I Thought I Knew

Vincent van Gogh - *Self-Portrait*, 1887

This was a different kind of recognition. I knew the face before I knew this particular painting. Van Gogh has become so familiar that it is easy to meet the biography before meeting the paint.

In person, what struck me was the surface: the short dabs of color around the face, beard, coat, and background. Seen just after Seurat, the connection was unexpectedly visible. The museum's own account notes how Van Gogh was responding to the pointillist experiments he encountered in Paris.

For a moment I tried not to turn him into the tragic figure I already knew. This was simply a man looking at himself - and, because he painted the encounter, allowing strangers more than a century later to look back.



04

A Fingerprint Large Enough to Sit On

Nifemi Marcus-Bello - *Friction Ridge Bench, Oriki (Act I)*

I first saw an unusual bench. Then I saw the fingerprint. Something normally confined to the tip of a finger had become monumental.

As a Nigerian, I appreciated encountering contemporary Nigerian design in this museum - not Nigeria preserved safely in the archaeological past, but Nigeria participating in a modern conversation about identity, materials, technology, and making.

A polished object can make labor disappear. The enlarged fingerprint did the opposite. It made the human trace enormous.



05

Objects Have Histories

Nifemi Marcus-Bello - *Headrest, Oriki (Act III)*

The related headrest shifted my attention from identity to material. A headrest is intimate: a human body rests against it. But the material came from somewhere, passed through other hands, and carries a history that a finished object can easily conceal.

That thought followed me toward technology. A phone, a computer, and even the so-called cloud can feel weightless when I use them, but they are not. They depend on minerals, factories, electricity, labor, transport, and physical infrastructure.

Nothing arrives from nowhere. The question I carried away was simple: **What had to happen in the world for this object to arrive in front of me?**



INTERLUDE

I photographed this before I knew what to call it.

That is worth preserving too. A museum visit does not have to be a sequence of successful identifications.

One of the risks of carrying artificial intelligence in my pocket is that every encounter can become a workflow: photograph, identify, explain, move on. But identification is not the same thing as understanding.

Sometimes curiosity should be allowed to remain curiosity for a while.



06

Nighthawks

Edward Hopper, 1942

What the museum told me. Hopper's diner is imagined rather than a literal portrait of one place; the label emphasizes the isolation of the figures and even notes the absence of a visible entrance.

What I saw. Bright light without warmth. People physically close, yet somehow separated. As a viewer, I could see inside the glass but could not enter.

What it opened in me. I was in Chicago with my family. The contrast mattered. Four people together in the painting were not necessarily less lonely than one person alone.



07

The Rock

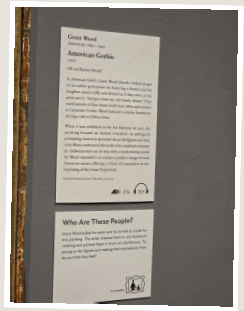
Peter Blume, 1944-48

The museum: the label connects Blume's difficult, crowded imagery to devastation and reconstruction around World War II, while acknowledging that the painting resists easy interpretation.

Me: I was not sure whether I found it hopeful. People were rebuilding, but the wreckage had not disappeared.

That uncertainty felt familiar. Technology often promises to rebuild medicine. Yet we frequently digitize an old bad workflow and call the result modernization.

The question is not only how quickly we can rebuild. It is what deserves to be rebuilt.



Grant Wood
American Gothic
1930
Oil on board
In American Gothic, Grant Wood created a work of art that captures the essence of rural life in the United States. The painting depicts a man and a woman standing in front of a white farmhouse with a large barn in the background. The man, on the right, is balding with glasses, wearing a dark jacket over a light shirt and blue overalls, and holding a pitchfork. The woman, on the left, has blonde hair and is wearing a dark dress with a white collar. The painting is framed in a simple wooden frame.

Who Are
These People?

08

American Gothic

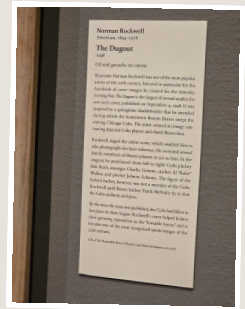
Grant Wood, 1930

The museum: Wood used his sister and dentist as models. The label also preserves an ambiguity often lost in parody: some viewers read satire, while Wood described a positive image of rural American values.

What I saw: restraint. The pitchfork, clothing, faces, and house all seemed disciplined.

What I thought about: generations in which affection was expressed less by words than by work - providing, remaining, repairing, getting up and doing the necessary thing again.

There is dignity in that. There can also be a cost when duty becomes so visible that tenderness disappears.



09

The Dugout

Norman Rockwell, 1948

The museum: Rockwell staged and photographed the scene for a *Saturday Evening Post* cover, contrasting dejected Chicago Cubs players with delighted Boston Braves fans.

I liked that he did not paint the triumphant moment. He painted the dugout.

Medicine, software, leadership, and fatherhood all reward competence. But some days do not go well. Sometimes because of mistakes, sometimes despite preparation, sometimes because life simply goes somewhere you did not expect.

The crowd remembers the score. The person in the dugout has to decide whether to come back tomorrow.



Slim Wasson

Born 1911 - died June 16, 1965

Twenty Mule Team

About 1942

Painted wood, leather, metal wire and hardware, rubber, and cotton

Arthur "Slim" Wasson worked at Ford's Lightning Ranch, a grand horse ranch of Santa Fe. Wasson rode cattle under the line across border, cattle under the world, and spent his retirement on the property carrying seed and horses. His sculpture is his final and largest work. It was once owned by actress Loretta Young, who called Wasson a "folk and great last art sculpture figure in America." The Wasson heritage where Wasson lived and worked had long been inspired by its natural and animal resources, and the sculpture often wandered off to the state line of Texas, where it is the Mule Team.

The sculpture is the gift of Arthur and Slim Wasson to the

10

A Small World Carrying a Large History

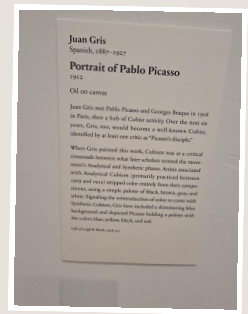
Arthur "Slim" Wasson - *Twenty Mule Team*

I did not expect a miniature mule team to hold my attention. It did.

Miniatures make large systems manageable. Industry becomes a wagon. Labor becomes a figure. A vast landscape occupies a few feet.

Families do something similar with memory. Decades become stories: *Remember when...* Told often enough, a story becomes part of what a family believes itself to be.

This book is doing the same thing. I am taking one rainy afternoon in Chicago and constructing a memory of it.



11

Picasso, Seen by Someone Else

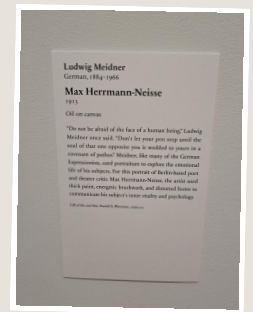
Juan Gris - *Portrait of Pablo Picasso*, 1912

I knew I was looking at a man, but the man had been taken apart. I could recognize a portrait only after surrendering the expectation that a portrait should behave like a photograph.

Later, a simpler thought stayed with me: this was one artist looking at another.

We all create versions of ourselves - biographies, websites, photographs, CVs. But my wife sees a version of me my colleagues do not. My sons see another. Patients see another.

What does another person see in me that I cannot see from inside myself?



12

A Face Before a Biography

Ludwig Meidner - *Max Herrmann-Neisse*

A few minutes earlier I had looked at Picasso through Juan Gris's eyes. Now another face confronted me.

Medicine teaches you to look at faces. Pain has a face. Anxiety has a face. Fatigue has a face. Grief has a face.

A chart can contain extraordinary amounts of truth about a patient while still failing to contain the person.

I am glad I saw this face before I learned the biography. History came later. Humanity came first.



13

Body, Machine, or Both?

Fernand Léger - *Composition in Blue*

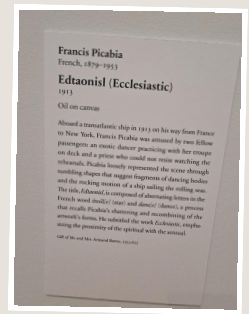
My first reaction was not sophisticated: I was trying to figure out what I was looking at.

Body? Machine? Architecture?

We are again living through a moment when the line between human and machine is being renegotiated. I speak and a machine transcribes me. Software summarizes. Artificial intelligence generates language.

I find this exciting. I also think we should notice what it does to our understanding of ourselves.

Where does the machine end, and where do I begin?



14

Not Everything Needs to Be Solved

Francis Picabia - *Edtaonisl (Ecclesiastic)*

This was one of the works I could not make behave. Even the title seemed determined not to help me.

Information did not make the painting obvious. I think I liked that.

There was an irony in walking through a museum in 2026 with artificial intelligence available on my phone. I could identify a work and obtain an explanation in seconds.

But identification can masquerade as understanding.

I am still not sure what I think about this painting. I want that sentence to remain in the book.



BACK INTO CHICAGO

For several hours I had been looking at other people's attempts to preserve human experience. Then I returned to the city with the people whose lives actually belong to mine.



The museum happened inside a birthday weekend. Chidiebere was twenty-four. Chi Chi, Obi, Nnamdi, Chidiebere, and I were together in Chicago. I can return to a painting. I cannot return to exactly this afternoon.

That does not make the afternoon sad. It makes it valuable.

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Final edition